

GRE Vocabulary Notes: Group 35

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1. Aplomb

Meaning: Calm confidence, especially in a difficult situation.

Tip to remember: Aplomb sounds like “a calm bomb.” Even if a bomb-like problem appears, a person with aplomb stays calm.

Sentence: She answered the difficult interview questions with aplomb.

2. Apposite

Meaning: Highly relevant, suitable, or appropriate.

Tip to remember: Apposite sounds like “appropriate.” An apposite example fits the topic perfectly.

Sentence: The professor gave an apposite example to explain the theory.

3. Beholden

Meaning: Owing gratitude or obligation to someone.

Tip to remember: Think of someone holding a favor over you. If you are beholden, you feel obligated.

Sentence: He felt beholden to his mentor for years of guidance.

4. Belittle

Meaning: To make someone or something seem less important.

Tip to remember: Belittle contains “little.” To belittle someone is to make them feel little.

Sentence: A good teacher should encourage students, not belittle them.

5. Cluster

Meaning: A group of similar things close together.

Tip to remember: Think of grapes growing together in one bunch. That bunch is a cluster.

Sentence: A cluster of students gathered near the notice board.

6. Coherent

Meaning: Clear, logical, and well-organized.

Tip to remember: Coherent sounds like “connect here.” A coherent idea has all parts connected clearly.

Sentence: Her essay was coherent and easy to follow.

7. **Contemplate**
Meaning: To think deeply about something.
Tip to remember: Think of sitting quietly in a temple and thinking deeply. That is contemplation.
Sentence: He contemplated applying for graduate school abroad.
8. **Crafty**
Meaning: Clever in a tricky or deceptive way.
Tip to remember: Crafty contains “craft.” A crafty person uses clever tricks like a skilled craft.
Sentence: The crafty salesman hid the product’s weaknesses.
9. **Dismantle**
Meaning: To take apart or break down into pieces.
Tip to remember: Think of removing the parts of a machine one by one. That is dismantling.
Sentence: The engineers dismantled the old generator.
10. **Elaborate**
Meaning: Detailed and complicated; to explain in more detail.
Tip to remember: Elaborate sounds like “labor.” An elaborate design requires a lot of labor and detail.
Sentence: The speaker elaborated on the causes of voltage instability.
11. **Exegesis**
Meaning: A detailed explanation or interpretation of a text.
Tip to remember: Think of extracting meaning from a passage line by line. That detailed explanation is exegesis.
Sentence: The scholar wrote an exegesis of the ancient poem.
12. **Forgo**
Meaning: To give up or do without something.
Tip to remember: Forgo means to let something go.
Sentence: He decided to forgo social media during GRE preparation.
13. **Impenetrable**
Meaning: Impossible to enter, pass through, or understand.
Tip to remember: Penetrate means enter. Impenetrable means cannot be entered or understood.
Sentence: The forest was so dense that it seemed impenetrable.
14. **Impervious**
Meaning: Not affected or influenced by something; unable to be penetrated.
Tip to remember: Think of a raincoat that water cannot pass through. It is impervious to water.
Sentence: He seemed impervious to criticism.

15. **Inalienable**

Meaning: Impossible to take away or transfer.

Tip to remember: Inalienable rights are rights that cannot be alienated, or taken away.

Sentence: Freedom of speech is often considered an inalienable right.

16. **Inept**

Meaning: Unskilled, clumsy, or incompetent.

Tip to remember: Apt means suitable or skilled; inept means not apt or not skilled.

Sentence: His inept handling of the issue made the problem worse.

17. **Martinet**

Meaning: A strict disciplinarian who demands exact obedience.

Tip to remember: Think of a military officer who enforces every rule harshly. That person is a martinet.

Sentence: The new supervisor was a martinet who tolerated no lateness.

18. **Narcissism**

Meaning: Excessive love or admiration of oneself.

Tip to remember: Narcissus, from myth, fell in love with his own reflection. Narcissism means self-obsession.

Sentence: His narcissism made teamwork difficult.

19. **Objurgation**

Meaning: Harsh criticism or scolding.

Tip to remember: Objurgation sounds like “objection with anger.” It means angry scolding.

Sentence: The student faced objurgation after repeatedly ignoring instructions.

20. **Passable**

Meaning: Acceptable but not excellent; good enough.

Tip to remember: Passable means it can pass, but just barely.

Sentence: His first draft was passable, but it needed improvement.

21. **Penetrating**

Meaning: Deep, sharp, and insightful; able to see through complexity.

Tip to remember: A penetrating look or idea goes through the surface and reaches the truth.

Sentence: The professor made a penetrating analysis of the problem.

22. **Picturesque**

Meaning: Visually attractive, like a picture.

Tip to remember: Picturesque means beautiful enough to be in a picture.

Sentence: The village looked picturesque against the mountain background.

23. **Reflect**

Meaning: To think deeply; to show or mirror something.

Tip to remember: A mirror reflects your face; your actions reflect your values.
Sentence: His calm response reflected his maturity.

24. **Resourceful**

Meaning: Good at finding clever ways to solve problems.

Tip to remember: A resourceful person can create resources even when resources are limited.

Sentence: The resourceful student solved the problem with simple tools.

25. **Retrench**

Meaning: To reduce spending, costs, or activities.

Tip to remember: Think of cutting a trench backward to save resources. Retrench means cut back.

Sentence: The company had to retrench after losing major clients.

26. **Self-indulgent**

Meaning: Allowing oneself too much pleasure or comfort.

Tip to remember: Self-indulgent means indulging yourself too much instead of showing discipline.

Sentence: Spending the whole day watching videos was self-indulgent.

27. **Speculate**

Meaning: To guess or form an opinion without complete evidence.

Tip to remember: Speculate sounds like “spectacles.” You try to look into an unclear future.

Sentence: Analysts speculated about the cause of the power outage.

28. **Staid**

Meaning: Serious, respectable, and not lively or adventurous.

Tip to remember: Staid sounds like “stayed.” A staid person stays within safe, proper limits.

Sentence: The meeting had a staid and formal atmosphere.

29. **Suppress**

Meaning: To stop, control, or prevent something from being expressed.

Tip to remember: Suppress sounds like “press down.” To suppress something is to press it down.

Sentence: The government tried to suppress criticism.

30. **Vestigial**

Meaning: Remaining only as a small trace of something that once existed.

Tip to remember: Think of a vestige, a leftover trace. Vestigial means leftover and no longer very useful.

Sentence: The appendix is often described as a vestigial organ.